

Salvation for the Damned

T.S

A village devoid of kindness is visited by a man that purports to bestow all that one may desire.

Rebekka grimaced at the copper bowl in front of her. Brown mush floated in the greasy broth, while bronze flecks decayed from the basin's sides. It caused her meal to sparkle.

The problem wasn't quality, it was quantity, Rebekka would eat the whole bowl if she could. Once she had wolfed down the soup, she began licking the walls of the bowl, her tongue burning from a metallic taste. It did nothing to quell the deep rumble in her belly.

"You eat too fast Bekka. You must learn to enjoy your food."

Nimrota, her favorite brother, gurgled his soup playfully. It made her giggle.

The rest of the family at the dinner table, her brothers, sisters, mother and father, looked on disapprovingly. There was no time for laughter. Or more likely, none of her family had the capacity for it. The winter had been as harsh as any other.

The whole village was just as cynical. Receiving a scowl from her neighbors was a blessing. It meant that they weren't planning on doing anything worse. Rebekka had once been followed by two young men one bright afternoon. Lack of food made it easy to escape when they tried to pin her down; their sinewy arms had almost snapped to 94KM*gguythe touch.

The exertion had caused her to be bedridden for a day. This had culminated in her being unable to move for a week. Her father had punished her with the belt; it was unacceptable that she had been unfit to work.

"No ... talking. Conserve ... strength." Her mother whispered through chapped lips. Rebekka stared across the wooden table, their thatched roof and hard mulch walls failing to keep the chill out of her bones.

She bowed her head, focusing on her hands. They were rough and dirty. Except for her left pinky, it was unblemished. Soon she would paint the nail blue. She used to have a green nail, before washing it off in fear of anyone noticing. This time though, she would show Nimrota. Rebekka felt his hand on her shoulder, and she looked up at his sad smile.

He opened his mouth but was interrupted by the loud banging of drums.

There was a visitor in town.

The family looked at each other with hesitation.

Newcomers weren't welcome in the village. There just wasn't anything for the townspeople to give. All the crops were dead. The farm animals had been butchered, with not a scrape of flesh, fur or bone wasted. Traders who asked for gold were dismayed when the villagers said that they had no silver.

They had nothing to offer the friendly. Imagine how the hostile treated them.

The drums, usually an ominous warning, were being played loud and incessantly, and were accompanied by a sound unheard of in the village.

Cheers.

Her mother howled in disapproval as Nimrota and Rebekka ran out into the muddy street. Other villagers stood outside their disheveled, thatched cottages, frozen in shock as they stared at the figure moving past.

Where the thick mud made one trudge, this man glided.

His garments were bright and regal, a crimson jacket on top of a white shirt. Bright cream pants hung over brown leather boots. His hair was golden, and he stood taller than any man Rebekka had ever seen, a chiseled face outlined by a shaped beard and moustache.

As the man moved past, Rebekka saw a congregation of villagers following him. Some were celebrating, others were speechless, while even more went to touch him, before pulling their muddy and blackened hands away.

One could not poison his cleanliness with the dirt of life.

Rebekka turned to see her whole family behind.

"He is not of this world," her father breathed.

"Does that mean he is the savior? Or a demon?" her mother replied. Nimrota grabbed Rebekka's hand.

"Who cares?" Her brother admonished. "It doesn't matter if we serve God or the Devil, both will keep us dancing."

They joined the march. The man and the cohort following him moved through the village, the stink of piss, shit and rot swept away by his intoxicating perfume.

Soon, they reached the town's square. The man swept forward and turned to face the mass of villagers watching. He stooped to his knees, and with a clean, manicured hand, scooped up some mud. He blew onto it.

Incredibly, it turned into a chunk of grass, roots breaking through the dirt. Wind began to swish the ferns from side to side, the man's hair and coat blowing as well.

Rebekka gasped at the sudden green. It was so ... vivid. She faintly remembered playing on grass when she was smaller. She had felt the wetness of the dew but couldn't see it on her clothes. Not like the brown mud, which marred everything these days.

With a flourish, the man dropped the grass, and with one hand beckoned everyone forward.

A combination of startlement and suspicion rippled among the townsfolk.

Until Nimrota stepped forward. Rebekka felt a stab of fear as her brother knelt, clasping the stranger's hand with two dirty palms.

The golden man held Nimrota's palms with delicacy, leaned forward and kissed his forehead. Gasps rang through the square. Golden sparks danced across her brother's body. Impossibly, dirt particles separated from his clothes and skin, falling to the ground. When Nimrota stood up, it seemed that he had grown taller by an inch.

Nimrota was *clean*. His body was in peak physical shape, muscles, hair and clothes gleaming. He looked at Rebekka and smiled bright white teeth.

The crowd began to bustle forward, lining up in front of the golden man.

The stranger made a circular twiddle in the air with his finger, and around the courtyard, golden walls sprang up. They were semi-transparent, Rebekka couldn't barely see through the topaz color.

Rebekka looked back at the man. He was beginning to kiss the foreheads of those kneeling before him.

Golden sparks became as plentiful as rain, as the starving townspeople transformed. Weak bodies became strong. Dirty, stilted hair grew long and thick. Everyone's physical attractiveness skyrocketed, men grew tall with bulging muscles, and the women developed full, red lips. Some ladies even had their eyelashes grow and curl, the bushy brows mimicking that which could be glued on. Once the golden man had kissed most of the villagers, they began to circle each other with excitement.

Everyone was dressed like royalty. The men's smooth jerkins and pants elegantly matched the ladies' colorful dresses.

Once they realised that the golden walls restricted their departure, they mingled around impatiently. They wanted to leave, to attack the world.

Rebekka herself was the last to receive the blessing. She moved forward in the line. The person in front of her spasmed in ecstasy when she was kissed, their brown flesh shedding layers of mud. Rebekka smelt the poignant lavender scent swirl around the lucky woman.

"Thank you m'lord!" The woman curtsied and scurried away.

It was Rebekka's turn.

She saw the golden man.

And cried out. He was a husk of the beauty that had glided through her village. His golden hair had faded into grey, cheeks gaunt and his skin blackening. Haggard and old, the man shone a horrid smile at her, filled with missing teeth. When he grasped her hand, she

shrieked again. It was uglier than her palms, yellow boils blistered the skin. She felt one pop, the slime moistening her hand. Rebekka yanked her fist away to take a step back.

It was not out of disgust.

It was out of sadness.

"No I cannot take your gift. Give it to yourself sir. Please."

The man bowed and pressed his hand to his chest.

Proud of herself, Rebekka walked to her brother next to the golden wall. She didn't mind that she had made the sacrifice.

"Hey, let us out!"

The townspeople turned to their savior with angry, beautiful faces. The walls had not come down.

A group of men swaggered over to him.

"What is this? Let us out will you."

The haggard mess that stood in the place of the golden man said nothing. He swayed slightly, his thin and frail legs barely keeping him upright. One of the men grabbed his jerkin and raised a fist.

"Leave him alone!" Nimrota yelled out from the walls. Two of the gang turned towards him.

"Or what? What are you going to do? Come over here and save him then."

Nimrota bowed his head and said nothing.

The youth holding the haggard man screamed, spit flying.

"I said let us out!" Each word was enunciated with a punch to the man's face. The golden man, the savior of the town, who had given them the impossible gift of youth, was propelled to the ground, blood and teeth splattering in the mud. He had used an arm to try and arrest his fall. It snapped with a wet crunch, the white bone spearing through his elbow. He groaned as one of the men kicked him.

The beating lasted a few seconds, then the men walked back to the golden walls and began banging them. None of the other villagers spoke up.

Rebekka ran to their fallen savior.

"I'm so sorry," she whimpered, stroking the man's hair. The grey roots came out by the plentiful. The man took his now half-bald head to look at her. He smiled, and despite the violence, the blood and lack of molars, Rebekka felt some of the radiance he had had earlier.

He spoke. It was raspy, stunted. It sent shivers down her spine.

"Good ... bad ... all ... same."

The man began convulsing. His skin ripped and his mouth opened unnaturally wide. That's when he exploded.

His skin ripped off his body, flying in all directions. For a brief moment, Rebecca could see the muscles and organs underneath, they were pure black. That was when a noxious green gas hissed out of his body. Rebekka was frozen in place, yet the dampening mist slid past her, as if she sat in a protective bubble. The townspeople stared in surprise, but were indifferent.

Until the gas reached its first victim.

The smoke entered the women's orifices, and her hands grew quadruple the size, both as large as the stump of an oak tree. Her sharp, angelic features curled into a scream, and without warning, she smashed her gigantic palms into her head. Blood and brain matter showered the area. Silence reigned as red droplets trickled down the golden walls.

The screaming began when the green gas continued to spread. People began moving to all corners of the area they were imprisoned in, their desperate attempts to break through the walls failing. There was nowhere to go, no way to escape from the noxious mist.

The fog slowly grew, taking its time to infect the townspeople. When it did, it was vicious. The contagion was unique for every individual.

Some transformed into monsters, lizard skin and beaks erupting out of faces. They began eating their peers, yellow beaks lunging forward to pierce necks.

One man chivalrously threw his wife behind him, spreading his body to protect her from the gas. Once he was engulfed, his skin *liquified*, the flesh dripping off of his body as if it was oozy paint. His wife screamed as he felt backwards on her. The puddles of his skin dripped onto her and she howled again; the droplets were like liquid fire, smearing into her and almost swallowing her up. After a while all that was left of the couple was a quagmire of pink muck. It was most horrific when it started to move, sliding sideways to leave a trail of discharge in its wake.

Eventually, the whole area contained by the walls had been engulfed by the mist. It was difficult to see through it, but it was easy to hear the moans, yells and grunts of townspeople transforming.

Rebekka lay on the ground crying. The mist had now taken her, flooding into her nose and mouth. Surprisingly she had felt no change when she had inhaled the toxins.

Shadows danced in the fog. Fear rode her heartbeat, until someone appeared.

It was Nimrota. His body had turned into stone. His arms and legs had no distinguishable features and were just rectangular blocks.

Rebekka only knew it was him due to his head.

Agony was etched in every line of his face, his eyes black and mouth impossibly wide open. It was set in stone, never to move again.

He strode with powerful steps to stand next to her. Waiting.

"Nimrota? Are you ok?" Rebekka whimpered. There was no response.

She turned to the golden man, he was still lying on his stomach. He tilted his head at her to reveal a crooked smile.

The man raised both hands in the air, and brought them to his face to cover his jaw. The fog began to form a whirlpool above them, before being sucked back into his mouth, fingers leaving gaps to around his lips.

The mist disappeared, but the air was still tainted, a green hue remaining. Rebekka could now see clearly.

Monsters roared in the air. Some were feasting, ripping apart their neighbors with beaks and talons stained in red. The golden walls had disappeared. Many began shambling away, to see what the outside world had in store for them.

The dead littered the ground. Some were missing limbs; others had been partly transformed. Those that hadn't perished whimpered, waiting for the end.

It wouldn't take long.

Rebekka spied her family. They had been transformed into scarecrows, their faces moving in fear as their bodies had been pierced through by some sort of iron pole, their limbs black and shriveled.

Movement distracted her from the horror. It was the man. He had stood up.

His golden hair shone above his crimson jerkin. He stood tall, somehow, he seemed to have gained height. The bruises from his beating had disappeared. His perfume danced tantalizingly around his figure, and with a straight posture, he breathed in the air with satisfaction.

Rebekka, still guarded by her towering brother, stammered out the question.

"Why?"

The man looked at her. Then continued on his way, swaying merrily as he left the madness behind.

Rebekka was stunned. Until she felt ... something. She looked down at her arm. There, on her forearm, was a bump. It was moving. Rebekka watched with fascination, then with horror, as it multiplied, each small goosebump growing in size to be as large as cysts. They began to move all around her body.

One burst.

A maggot, white and wrinkly, edged its head out of the wound. It flew out, to land in Rebekka's mouth. Her cries stopped when it slid down her esophagus. Rebekka didn't think too hard about why it had re-entered her body just after escaping it.

All the other bumps had begun to burst.

They had the same idea as their counterpart. And they wouldn't all fit in her mouth.

The End